

investors' confidence; it can affect the trust that the people of India have in India's own institutions... So, I won't do it now.' But after 10 full years of us clearly delivering on our promises... taking [the] Indian economy closer to being the third-largest economy... we are now in a safe position to say to the people of India this is exactly what we inherited.

RK: Earnings reports of several FMCG companies seem to suggest that there has been a 20-30% decline in rural consumption. How do you look at this?

A: I wouldn't just put them aside... But I'm not sure it is 20-30%... FMCG companies do have metrics which we need to take seriously because it indicates quick buying of durable goods. But equally, it is not correct to say

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that rural distress is continuing. Because I think there's a shift in the way in which the rural economy is going... because money is going in—in the name of one or the other scheme, to every family in the rural area. I would dare say this, that there is no family left without getting at least one or the other scheme of the government...

The rural economy is also looking at a changing paradigm in agriculture. A lot of commercial crops are coming in... the linkages through the e-National Agriculture Market [for selling]... farmers are now seeing potential to move to different crops... The emphasis given to horticulture is finding newer markets within their locality... It's no longer a wheat and rice economy. It is a lot more of horticulture, fisheries... livestock is gaining a lot of attention, also supported by the policy of the government. SHGs [self-help groups], that are now into value addition in food, and also with the mechanisation of agriculture which is bringing the monopoly down.

SZ: You linked secularism to saturation of the

availability of all government schemes. Is that now the new definition of secularism that the Modi government is pushing out?

A: That's right. And not just in the 2024 elections, even in 2019, by which time the Ujjwala [LPG cylinder scheme] had reached good dimensions. You had people belonging to different communities, particularly women... who came out to say, 'Yes, I'm benefitting with a gas cylinder.' People who came out to say that 'Ujjwala has helped me to bring clean air in my kitchen, and I'm more efficient in getting my food done' belong to all communities. Even at that time, it was observed... that the Ujjwala scheme's implementation has proven that every eligible person gets it... So that litmus test of secularism in action has been felt even in 2019. Now it's felt even more. If secularism has to be practised, you don't need to pander to religious beliefs. If you're able to, across the board, give everybody everything... you are indifferent to the person's faith or religion, but make sure he or she is as good as the other next door—that's secularism in action.

RK: Household savings is said to be at a five-decade low at 5.1%. How are you looking at the aspect of households seeming to save much lesser than they have in the past decades?

A: That is not the necessary conclusion you can arrive at... Because as much as you talk about small savings... the only option that the middle class had for saving their money with some confidence was to put it in, let's say, post office savings account, which continues... But you're also noticing since 2020, that because of greater transparency and greater availability of information, people are able to see which are the performing companies [in the stock market]. They're not even going through the route of mutual funds to understand how the stock market performs. Small savings in the name of retail funding is coming into the stock markets, and coming through demat accounts that are unique... [that] tell you that probably many savings that went to post offices are now coming into the market.

RK: One of the critiques we've heard from the Opposition is that when it comes to social sectors, the percentage of government outlays on education and health have come down as a percentage of GDP. And the outlays are not being fully spent. How do you look at this?

A: On the outlays not getting spent, I may not be the best person to answer. I will be concerned as to why the outlays are not getting spent. But it will be the department's and particularly in education and health,